Millie

By Susan J Kander

INTRODUCTION

When faced with a loved one's illness, things change. Things don't happen the way they once did, life doesn't run as smoothly. When Millie's husband falls ill she is no longer just a wife and mother. She is his nurse, his caretaker, his janitor and ultimately, his life support. She must strive hard to remain the same woman she was . . . . to be just "Millie" by Susan J. Kander.

(Lights up on an empty bedroom. Millie enters wearing a bright print sack of a dress and house shoes, her face the picture of fatigue. She walks around what we understand to be a bed, and blows a somewhat perfunctory kiss to the occupant of the bed.)

MILLIE: You think somebody's trying to tell me something or something? They done smashed up my car now for good and all. Can you believe it? Every car I get, somebody feel they got to smash it up for me. Now I got to find me another one, and I got to ask Mr. Lewis to help me out. God I hate that. But I got to get myself back on rubber again, and soon. You know I was thinking, while I was serving the rolls around the table for the tenth time- now why she got to go and have a sit-down brunch the one Saturday I got big night-time plans? Anyway, I was thinking, you know, about getting me a Mack Truck, so instead of peoples running my car all the time, I can get to tearing up some other peoples' cars! *(laughs)* Oh Honey, I am almost too tired to laugh, and you know that's serious! . . . Shoot, now I got to go out tonight in Sam's old raggedy car. And even worse, I got to let him drive. I never let him drive my car. I got no interest in passing it around for other

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peoples to smash it up for me, hell no. I just said a sweet word, didn't I, baby? Specially, furthermore, since Sam like his whiskey and I only drink Coca-cola, ain't that right? I have a Coke and I smile. What you bobbing your big head around for, Honey? It's the truth. Pop pop pop? Oh, okay, yeah, you right, I drink Orange Pop. Yeah, so do you, so do you. You didn't get to be over two hundred pounds sitting up in that bed drinking ice tea! You like it when I say sweet words, don't you? You like this dress? Mrs. Lewis brang it to me from Hawaii. *(Crossing to vanity)* She never bring me candy no more, old spoil sport. "It's for your own good, Millie; you know it." No I don't know it. Sam love me, he said, just the way I am. Yeah, and I believed him so much, I started doing his laundry for him. Like the last thing I need in the world ain't more folks' dirty clothes. *(Begins to apply make-up)* this morning I got to work, Mrs. Lewis look at me and said "Millie, you look like death warmed over. Did Honey keep you up all night again?" Like you had your seizures on purpose or something. "Why don't you go upstairs and take a nap?" Seem like she can tell by my face when you've had a seizure in the night, or messed in your bed. She look in my face, at the ring around my eyes, see I'm so tired I could cry. And *then* she says "You look like death warmed over." Dear God, is that necessary? . . . Boy, Honey, one of these days you're going to have one too many. That's how Dr. Brackett says it works. . . . Oh, she's only trying to be nice, I know. She don't sleep too good neither, sometimes. Yeah, someday I am going to say to her "Hey Mrs. Lewis, didn't you get no sleep last night? Now we both look like a corpse reheated!" *(laughs)* See how she did that for Good Morning. Shoot, I think if I did it once, I'd want to do it every day: drive

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in the driveway, walk in the door and fall into bed. Yeah, that used to be my only complaint about Sam: he may be a old raggedy man, but he never let me get my rest at night. *(laughs)* Now he's dumb enough to think all he's got to do is take me to see Teddy Pendergrass at the Uptown Theater and I'm going to start doing his laundry again? What kind of a dumb broad does he think I am? Sure is nice, though, have a man around, for whatever the need arise. . . . That was a long time ago, that first time: a long time. A lot more done changed in old Teddy's life, God bless his heart, than in mines. His life took a real dive: mines just stayed on the bottom of the ocean where it's been ever since you started growing that thing up in your head. Poor Teddy. I can't picture you in no wheelchair, man, not you with your beautiful voice and that beautiful body and the way you use it ooh boy! I can still see him, Honey, moving his meat to the beat ooh yeah. Teddy Teddy Teddy, put your meat on the beat boy and move it over my way. Ooh yeah. That man can do it to me any old time he want- ain't you the most stunning man I ever been in the same room with, never mind-oh never mind there's all the rest of the crowd here cause it's just you and me, Teddy, you and me. Oh yes! Ain't you... simply... stunning. . . I should have known Sam was low class right from the beginning when he offered me my choice between last row at Teddy Pendergrass and ring-side seats at All-star Wrestling. I knew he wanted me to choose wrestling, too! Almost did, too, just to make him like me. But I got hold of myself. I said "Mildred, what are you doing? He's giving you a choice: choose right." You would never have pulled that kind of stunt, I know that. You would have said "Kick off your house shoes, Sugar; we are stepping out." Like you

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did remember when you took me to the Mark: IV and we dined and we danced all night long-. . . . Listen to yourself, Mildred. Eleven years and listen to you. Dear God. Well, nothing stops the sand, Baby. Someday, somehow, it'll be better, ain't that right? . . . That was the first time I ever slipped out on you, long after the first surgery. I don't think it troubled Sam none, in fact I know it didn't. But it troubled me plenty and I wasn't going to do it for no All-star Wrestling! Not even Gorgeous George versus The Stomper! Yes, I said The Stomper, Honey, he's our man, yes I know; Millie know. No, it ain't on now; You already watched it today, come on at noon, remember? You watched it with Charles, when he come by to give you your lunch. It ain't on again 'til Monday. *(She has returned to vanity, and resumes with make-up and jewelry.)* Perry'll be by later on after I go. He'll sit with you watch the ball game, okay? Give you your dinner. He called me yesterday, asked could he come by and see his daddy, since he didn't feel like going out on no hot dates. *(laughs)* That old Perry. My baby some smart kid, ain't he? Smart? He's downright crafty. Twenty-three years old, junior college graduate, and ain't got no babies! Ain't even shacking with no one; and furthermore, ain't even looking for it. Now that's a crafty kid. Must of took a good lesson from Charles and Tony and all they babies. But imagine that, Honey: of all my boys, my baby a college graduate, working two jobs, money in his pants and ain't got no one to spend it on but his own self. And his old Mama, of course. He gave me these earrings, remember? And for no good reason, neither. Didn't even want me to feed him dinner or nothing. *(Fetching shoes out of a closet)* I can't believe it. I told them all three a million times, and you heard me say

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it: "You make babies, you keep them at your house. I'll visit, on Sundays, after church. Put your lady on the pill; wear a raincoat; do whatever you got to do cause I ain't bringing up your children. I'm tired." Now what do I get every morning but BANG goes the screen door and "Hey Grammaw, got any chocolate cake today?" (laughs) That baby Tony is so fat already, he's just a little butterball. . . I'll never know what went right with Perry, but he's as free as an eagle that boy. I ain't been that free since I was dragging the chair up to the cupboard and reaching my dirty little hand into Mama's sugarbowl. And even that wasn't free, cause she sent me out to pick my own switch for the whipping every time! *(laughs)* Your mama ain't sent so much as a pair of pajamas in eleven years. She don't care if I was to put you away in a nursing home. And she sure as hell ain't about to help pay for it. *(Sitting beside bed, putting on shoes)* Dr. Brackett started in about a home before you was even out of the hospital the first time, all 67 pounds of you. But he dried up about it when you started gaining weight for me. Then, after the second surgery, and the strokes, couldn't nobody understand you but me, and I said to him "How's anybody going to understand him when he's asking for his orange pop, or for the channel to be switched, or trying to tell somebody he done stooled in his bed again? No thank you, he stays home with me. I got my boys to help me out. They call him Daddy, you know, ever since we got married, me and Honey. So he stays home. . . . Two major surgeries, more strokes than I got fingers, and now all these seizures: Lord, Honey, how much can a person put up with huh? Ain't you tired yet? You got nothing left hardly but a mouth, and not even one good eye. Ain't you plain tired? How many more nights like last

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night, Honey, huh? I can't afford enough sets of sheets for you, and I get so tired of doing laundry in the middle of the night. Dear god, when are you going to get tired? Just plain wore out? . . . .No, why would you? All you do is sit up in that bed all day, watch TV and eat up my kitchen. You're happy... You know, you don't even look like the Honey I married. ..*(Rising, going back to vanity)* I guess I don't look too much like the Sugar you married anymore, now, do I? These black bags under my eyes. Hair needs touching up. I don't like my roots showing like that. Honey? What do you really think about this dress? Kind of makes me look like a. . . billboard. don't it? *(laughs)* I want Teddy to think I'm sexy. *(She puts on a belt that transforms the dress from sack to dynamite.)*. I got all of Saturday night just waiting for me and Teddy. And then I'll think about Sam. Old two-timing lizard. He just got to stay cool and wait for me, cause I promised myself I'm going to take myself backstage afterward and personally wish Mr. Teddy Pendergrass the best of luck and God bless him for the rest of his life. They better let me in back there" too: anybody get in my way I'll just sit on them-Boom!

Cause I'm going to see my Teddy, tell him "I'll drive your wheelchair any time you in town. You just keep singing, Mister; you keep on living, cause you can't afford to stop turn around look behind you, see how nice things used to be. You just keep your eyes going forward; look on ahead now. You keep singing your songs cause I want to hear them. I always want to keep hearing them, Teddy, you understand me? Always and always. . . "

Never look behind you. Never ever. That's what I'm going to tell Mr. Teddy Pendergrass when I see him tonight backstage at the Uptown

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Theater *(She hears something, turns abruptly to the bed; Honey is having a seizure.)* Oh! Don't fallout the bed, I can't get you up off the floor! *(Runs to vanity, searches the drawer for a box of individually wrapped tongue depressors. A car horn honks loudly offstage.)* Not now, Sam! Tonight! No more! *(She finds the box, wrenches it from the drawer and spills it on the floor. Drops to her knees to clean up the mess and find one depressor. She is frenzied.)* I can't do this no more! Too many! . . . Perry. . . Teddy. . . Teddy in your wheelchair! *(Doorbell rings. Millie freezes with the stick in her hand, there on her knees. Lights change.)*
(Almost as If in a dream) That's what I had to tell Dr. Brackett the other night at that party I did. "I seen you leave the buffet table, Doctor. You so embarrassed to see me you going to pass up my best rack of lamb with sage dressing rather than let Millie serve you? Well here. I brought you a plate, so I can tell you straight out once and for all: I see your eyes, I know what's in your heart, and you got it all wrong. This is me, Mrs. Clinton Gladies telling you Don't you feel sorry about what you done. Now just don't. I know you said six months, but you gave me eleven years with Honey I wouldn't of had without you, and even though you had to cut out some of the best part of him, what you left was more than I would have had otherwise. So don't you ever regret operating on him. *(laughing)* Besides, how could you know I'd be such a miraculous nurse? And he'd be such a hard-headed man? So you see, I'm not sad; I'm happy. This is a happy face, Doctor: a very happy face." *(Doorbell rings again. Millie comes back to the present, finds herself on her knees with the unused stick in her hand. She looks at the bed, then hurries to it, trembling.)* Honey? . . .

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Oh you made it, baby, you made it through again. . . . That's right, sleep. You sleep. *(Relieved, she turns, but sees now that he has messed in the bed during the seizure.)* Oh, dear God! *(Doorbell rings)* Sam? Sam! *(Doorbell rings in response)* Keep your pants on you old coot! *(She finds a clean set of sheets in the closet, starts to unfold them to remake the bed. She stops. Long moment, then)* Mildred, you cannot do this now. *(She puts sheets down, goes to vanity, gets pencil and paper, writes.)* "Dear Perry. Sorry, I *had* to go. Leave dirty sheets for me. . . . *(Drawing smile face)* Smile." *(Walks back to bed with note)* " You know, Honey, even if we'd of never went to see that old judge at all, you know you'd be right here, right now. Right here in this old bed, in this old room, in this old raggedy house; with this woman taking care of you. Cause you're my Honey, and I'm your Sugar. Ain't that right? *(Doorbell rings long and hard)* Get off my bell you old moose! I'm coming! *(Putting note on sheets, she goes to vanity, checks herself again, pulls herself together, takes up pocket book, starts to exit. Stops, blows Honey a kiss, takes a deep breath, looks straight ahead, and exits.)*

SOURCE INFORMATION

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